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For all that his court ulema may have been hostile to innovation, Akbar was not; nor, for that matter, was his realm. This was a time of religious, social and political fermentation – beliefs and communities coalescing and breaking apart like so many amoebas evolving out of their single cells, while Akbar's empire (and his court) grew more complex and diverse with every annexation and every appointment. '[I]n those days,' as Badauni puts it, 'the chattels of learning had considerable currency' – so it was fitting that his interview at court took the form of a debate. 'The Emperor made me dispute with sages,' he writes, '. . . and was himself the arbiter.'

Abul Fazl, meanwhile, brought along a commentary on the *ayatul kursi*, a verse from the Quran popularly recited to ward off danger. No performative disputes for this shy twenty-three-year-old; just the handing over of his composition, and love at first sight. 'Love for that holy personality,' he would later write, 'took possession of my heart.'

Akbar's own first impressions of these two applicants are unrecorded. He would have had many things on his mind: just a few weeks after Badauni's and Abul Fazl's appearances in court, Akbar left Fatehpur for a conquest of the east. One may wonder why, then, he was spending time conducting job interviews. The answer may lie in the padishah's other preoccupation at this time: he was planning an overhaul of his administration.

Running a government, then as now, is expensive business,[18] and sixteenth-century Hindustani governments had two broad methods of generating revenue. One was loot. So, for example, Jouher describes Humayun's conquest of Champaner and the subsequent discovery of its treasures under a giant bath. Its water was drained and the treasure 'was immediately divided among the army, by filling the shield of each person with materials in proportion to his rank'.[19] Shields full of gold from secret hordes have an undeniable romance, but they do not make for long-term economic plans. Another, far more stable source of revenue was hidden in plain sight: not loot from fortresses but tax on economic activity, of which the most important, at this time, was agriculture.

It was already a decade or so since Akbar began a long struggle to ensure an uninterrupted and transparent flow of revenue from the fertile fields of Hindustan to the imperial treasury. Just now, for example, when he visited